

Markelo — Field Interview Discussion Guides

Read this before you interview anyone.

Rules for every interview

1. **Do not pitch Markelo.** This is research. If you describe the product first, the person will agree with you to be polite. You will learn nothing.
 2. **Ask about the last real event, not opinions.** Ask "tell me about the last time..." instead of "would you like...". People predict their own behaviour badly. They remember events well.
 3. **Ask to see things.** Ask for the control sheet, the mark sheet, the scanner, the result file. Artifacts are stronger evidence than answers.
 4. **Stay quiet after a question.** Count to five. The person will continue and give you the real answer.
 5. **Do not ask leading questions.** Say "How do you handle extra sheets?" Do not say "Extra sheets are difficult, correct?"
 6. **Record the exact words.** Write what they said, not your summary of it.
 7. **Time limit: 20 minutes.** If they offer more, continue. If they offer 10, use the questions marked ★.
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Guide 1 — Examination Officer / Records Officer

This is the most important role. They own the pipeline Markelo replaces.

Opening

"I am researching how examinations are managed in Nigerian institutions. I am not selling anything. I want to understand how your process works today. May I ask you some questions for about 20 minutes?"

Current process

1. ★ Walk me through one full examination, from creation to result release. What is the first thing you do?
2. ★ How many scripts do you handle in one examination period?
3. How do you know which script belongs to which student?
4. What records do you keep on paper, and what do you keep on a computer?
5. Show me the forms or sheets you use. (*Ask to photograph them.*)

The problem we believe exists

1. ★ Think about the last two examination periods. Did any script go missing? Tell me what happened.
2. How long did it take to resolve? Who was involved?
3. What happens when a student says their script was not marked?

Scanning and equipment

1. ★ What scanning or photocopying equipment does this office have? May I see it?
2. Who operates it? How many pages can it take at one time?

Results

1. ★ Where do you enter final results? Show me that system.
2. What file format does it accept?
3. Who controls that system — this office, or ICT?
4. What is your deadline for submitting results? What happens if it is late?

Closing

1. What is the single most frustrating part of your job during examination period?
 2. Who else should I speak to about this?
 3. May I have your contact details to follow up?
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Guide 2 — Lecturer

Opening

Same as above.

Marking today

1. ★ Tell me about the last set of scripts you marked. How many were there? How long did it take?
2. Where do you mark them — office, home, somewhere else?
3. ★ When you mark, do you see the student's name and matric number?
4. Has knowing whose script it is ever affected you? (*Ask neutrally. Do not suggest bias.*)
5. Does your institution have any written rule about hiding student identity during marking?

Delegation

1. ★ Who else marks scripts for your courses? How do you divide the work?
2. Is that arrangement official or informal?
3. How do you check the quality of their marking?

Devices and connectivity

1. ★ If you had to mark on a screen instead of paper, what device would you use?
2. How reliable is power and internet where you would mark?

Moderation and disputes

1. Has a student ever disputed a mark? What evidence did you use to answer them?
2. Who reviews your marking, and how?

Closing

1. If one thing about marking could change, what would it be?
 2. Who else should I speak to?
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Guide 3 — Teaching Assistant / Graduate Assistant

1. ★ How were you given scripts to mark? Who gave them to you?
 2. How many did you receive, and how long did you have?
 3. Did you see student names on the scripts?
 4. Did anyone check your marking afterwards?
 5. Were you paid or credited for this work? (*This tells us whether the role is formal.*)
 6. What was hardest about the work?
 7. What device do you own that you could mark on?
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Guide 4 — HOD / Dean / Moderator

1. ★ What is your role when examination results come to you?
 2. How do you check that marking was done properly? Do you review every script or a sample?
 3. How large is the sample, and how do you choose it?
 4. ★ Tell me about the last grade dispute you handled. What evidence did you have?
 5. What must you produce for accreditation review?
 6. ★ Who approves the purchase of new software for this department or faculty?
 7. What would make you distrust a digital marking system?
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Guide 5 — ICT Director / Head of ICT

This person is likely a gatekeeper and possibly the buyer. Do not skip this role.

1. ★ What systems does the institution already run for student records and results?
 2. Who built and who maintains them?
 3. ★ Where is student data allowed to be stored? Is external or cloud storage permitted?
 4. Do you have a written data-protection policy? May I see it?
 5. Has the institution refused an external system before? Why?
 6. ★ Who approves a new software purchase, and what is the process?
 7. When does the budget year run?
 8. What internet and power reliability does the campus have?
 9. What would a new system have to prove before you would allow it?
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Guide 6 — Student (short, 5–10 minutes)

1. ★ Have you ever had a result that was missing, delayed, or wrong? Tell me what happened.
 2. What did you do about it? Who did you contact?
 3. How long did it take to resolve?
 4. Do you believe your scripts are marked fairly? Why?
 5. Do you know whether your lecturer sees your name when marking?
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After every interview

Fill in the capture sheet ([04-capture-and-synthesis.md](#)) **within one hour**, while you still remember. Notes written the next day lose most of their value.
